Prologue

‘JEEJEBHOY, WHY NOT PLACE AN order with him?’ asked E.E. Sassoon, the wily and shrewd industrialist who controlled the Sassoon group of mills of his secretary. The man he wanted Jeejebhoy to place an order with was Purshotamdas Thakurdas, a partner with Narandas Rajaram & Co. Old Sassoon sourced his cotton from Vassanji Trikamji & Co., a well-established Indian firm which was his principal supplier. But news of a young trader who had recently become famous in cotton trading circles for the quality of his cotton had reached Sassoon and he wanted to see for himself the quality of Purshotamdas’s cotton. Feel would be a more appropriate word, for old Sassoon was blind, and he gauged the quality of cotton by rubbing it between his fingers. When Jeejebhoy demurred, saying that Purshotamdas’s prices were much higher than those quoted by Sassoon’s principal supplier, Purshotamdas argued his case by saying that he dealt in quality cotton. Sassoon, impressed by the young man’s earnestness, decided to give him a chance. He ordered 500 bales and when the consignment was checked, discovered that Purshotamdas had delivered what he had promised: his cotton was indeed of superior quality. Sassoon visited his mills to get feedback from his workers about the new cotton and the workers enthusiastically endorsed the new consignment.

‘Then what,’ demanded Sassoon of his cotton suppliers and brokers ‘have I been buying all these years?’[1] Sassoon got his entire stock of cotton examined and discovered that Purshotamdas’s cotton was far superior to anything his godowns stocked. He ordered his suppliers to replace every bale and overhauled his purchasing staff. Vassanji Trikamji and Co.